

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, mostly cloudy, not as chilly, high 44. **Tonight**, partly cloudy late, low 39. **Tomorrow**, some morning sun, afternoon clouds, warmer, high 52. Weather map is on Page B12.

VOL. CLXXV No. 60,828

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THURSDAY, MARCH 19, 2026

Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00



DAVID GUTTENFELDER/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Surveying the damage from Israeli airstrikes in central Beirut, Lebanon, on Wednesday that killed at least 10 and wounded 27 others.

Rally Planner On Jan. 6 Gets No-Bid Deals

**By DAVID A. FAHRENTHOLD
and ANDREA FULLER**

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration has bypassed regular procedures to award more than \$13 million in contracts to the company that helped organize President Trump’s rally on Jan. 6, 2021, repeatedly creating hidden business opportunities that only one firm could win.

Those contracts have transformed Event Strategies Inc., staffed by veterans of Mr. Trump’s campaigns and first White House, from a minor federal contractor into the government’s highest-paid event planner. The firm has arranged celebrations of the Navy’s 250th birthday and a Treasury Department event to tout new savings accounts for children, called “Trump accounts.”

By law, federal agencies are generally supposed to seek competing bids before awarding contracts, to get the best value for taxpayers. Event Strategies won contracts that were particularly lucrative, the kind that other companies say they would have liked to win.

In at least five cases, other firms never got the chance.

Instead, the agencies invoked legal loopholes meant for special situations — instances of urgent need, or cases where only one specialized vendor could do a job — and gave the contracts to Event Strategies.

Of the \$22 million in federal contracts that Event Strategies has received since Mr. Trump resumed office, the majority has come through these carve-outs. By contrast, less than 3 percent of the \$120 million the Trump administration awarded to other event planners involved similar exemp-

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Cesar Chavez Accused of Abusing Girls

Accounts Detail Years of Misconduct by a Civil Rights Icon

**By MANNY FERNANDEZ
and SARAH HURTES**

Ana Murguia remembers the day the man she had regarded as a hero called her house and summoned her to see him. She walked along a dirt trail, entered the rundown building, passed his secretary and stepped into his office.

He locked the door, as he always did when he called her, and told her how lonely he had been. He brought her onto the yoga mat that he often used in his office for meditation, kissed her and pulled her pants down. “Don’t tell anyone,” he told her afterward. “They’d get jealous.”

The man, Cesar Chavez, one of the most revered figures in the Latino civil rights movement, was 45. She was 13. Ms. Murguia said she was summoned for sexual encounters with him

dozens of times over the next four years.

Recently, more than 50 years later, Ms. Murguia learned that a street near her home in the Central California city of Bakersfield was in the process of being renamed. City officials want to name it in honor of her abuser.

Cesar Chavez Boulevard.

Ms. Murguia and another woman, Debra Rojas, say that Mr. Chavez sexually abused them for years when they were girls, from around 1972 to 1977. He was in his 40s and had become a powerful, charismatic figure who captured global attention as a champion of farmworker rights.

The two women have not shared their stories publicly before, and an investigation by The

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CARL CRAWFORD/FRESNO BEE/ZUMA PRESS, VIA REUTERS

Dolores Huerta, a prominent ally of Cesar Chavez, described two assaults in her 30s.

They Had a Mission: Deep Clean Epstein’s Online Reputation

**By TIFFANY HSU
and KEN BENSINGER**

An email sent to Jeffrey Epstein in September 2010 presented an intriguing opportunity. “Would you be interested,” it read, “in having all that crap that comes up on Google search on your name basically disappear?”

Mr. Epstein had been released from jail about a year earlier after a conviction for sex crimes involving a minor. His online reputation was a shambles. Less than two hours after receiving the email, he responded:

“Yes.”

That helped kick-start a years-long quest by Mr. Epstein to overhaul his online reputation, accord-

ing to a New York Times review of thousands of pages of emails, financial records and other records released by the Justice Department. The documents make clear that Mr. Epstein became deeply invested in hiding his criminal past in Google searches and on Wikipedia.

He never fully sanitized his web presence before he was arrested

again, in 2019, and charged with sex trafficking. But the effort at times allowed Mr. Epstein to maintain an air of respectability and preserve social contacts he might have lost had his crimes been more prominent online.

To accomplish that, Mr. Epstein first turned to the author of the

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Oil and Gas Prices Jump As Wave of Strikes Hits Energy Facilities in Iran

NEWS ANALYSIS

A History of Conflicts That All Fell Short

By NEIL MacFARQUHAR

After the United States and Israel went to war against Iran on Feb. 28, the U.S. military began issuing a bulletin every few days listing the number of targets hit. By Wednesday it was more than 7,800 in total, up from over 1,000 on the first day of the war, while a similar Israeli count of strikes stood at 7,600 late last week.

It is, by any measure, a bombing campaign of historic proportions, and senior U.S. officials have lauded it repeatedly as a crushing blow to the Iranian armed forces. “Never before has a modern, capable military, which Iran used to have, been so quickly destroyed and made combat ineffective, devastated,” Pete Hegseth, the secretary of defense, said at a news conference last week.

And yet, Iran is not entirely crippled militarily. It continues to retaliate, often in unconventional ways. Its resistance, along with the political defiance of its new leaders, evokes a decades-old pattern of unrealized expectations for American interventions in the region.

Global oil prices have surged upward as Iranian attacks have curtailed exports through the narrow, perilous Strait of Hormuz, including hitting a tanker on Tuesday near the waterway. Virtually every night, a barrage of Iranian missiles hits Israel and Persian Gulf nations allied with the United States, unsettling the population. Most cause little damage, but overall the fighting has killed more than 2,300 people in Iran, Lebanon, Israel and across the region.

Iranian proxy militias in Lebanon and Iraq have joined the fray, firing rockets into northern Israel and hitting the sprawling U.S. Embassy compound in Baghdad.

Despite the overwhelming force brought to bear against Iran, and the serial killings of its leaders, the regime has not toppled. Analysts are now weighing to what extent the promises of a “New Middle East” emerging from the conflict could prove as illusory as the ones from previous wars that embroiled Gaza, Lebanon and Iraq.

The United States has a tend-

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Tehran’s Intelligence Minister Is Killed in Israeli Attack

This article is by **Abdi Latif Dahir, Christina Goldbaum and Michael Levenson.**

Iran’s domestic energy sector came under heavy attack on Wednesday after airstrikes hit critical infrastructure used to generate electricity for its industries and homes, just hours after Israel killed Iran’s intelligence minister in another blow to the battered regime in Tehran.

Iran said that airstrikes had damaged a number of facilities connected to the South Pars gas field, a vast natural gas reservoir in the Persian Gulf, and had also hit oil and petrochemical facilities in the southern city of Asaluyeh, where gas from the South Pars field is pumped for processing.

Although it was not clear how much damage had been done, the



ARASH KHAMOUSHI FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Ali Larijani’s funeral procession in Tehran on Wednesday.

strikes could worsen Iran’s already severe domestic energy shortages. Iran and Qatar, which owns part of the gas field, blamed Israel for the attacks. Israel did not immediately comment.

After the strikes, oil and natural gas prices spiked, with the global benchmark for crude oil soaring to more than \$109 a barrel as investors worried that Iran would retaliate by striking oil and gas sites in the region, putting further pressure on crude supplies.

Gasoline prices in the United States have been rising since the start of the war, reaching \$3.84 a gallon on Wednesday. The Trump administration, in an effort to lower prices, said on Wednesday that it would temporarily relax a law that restricts the way oil is shipped within the United States.

Relaxing the law, known as the

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As Countertop Cutters Fall Ill, Companies Push for Immunity

By REBECCA DAVIS O’BRIEN

Jeff Rose, a 56-year-old grandfather in Georgetown, Ky., contracted a lethal lung disease doing a job he loves: carving kitchen countertops from slabs of quartz, a man-made product that has surged in popularity as an alternative to marble and granite.

Mr. Rose’s 30-year-old son, Skyler, followed his father into the stone-fabrication business and, like him, inhaled the tiny particles of silica that are released when quartz is cut. He contracted silicosis, too.

“It really hurts knowing I’m sick like this,” said Mr. Rose, who used to chop down the family Christmas tree but now loses his breath climbing a flight of stairs. “I love being creative with my hands. I’m not able to do that anymore.”

The Roses are among hundreds

of stone-fabrication workers who have been diagnosed with silicosis, a disease long associated with industrial toil that is afflicting more of the workers who help build American kitchens. The industry, confronting mounting litigation, is seeking legal immunity from Congress.

Representatives for manufacturers and distributors — many of them small businesses — say fabricated quartz, also known as engineered stone, is safe, and blame fabrication workshops further down the chain of production, where the slabs are cut to spec with improper equipment or precautions, for the surge in silicosis cases.

“The problem is the process, not the product,” said Rebecca Shult, the chief legal officer at

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D.H.S. Nominee’s Softer Tone
Markwayne Mullin set himself apart from the ousted Kristi Noem during his confirmation hearing. PAGE A15

Rift Over Schools in Idaho
Does “choice” mean vouchers for private schools or remote learning that brought AP classes to rural areas? PAGE A11

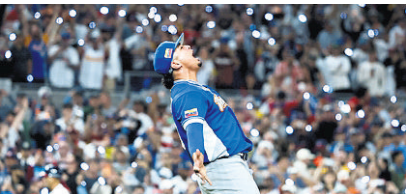
INTERNATIONAL A4-10

Africans Resent Travel Ban
Of the 36 countries covered by the Trump administration’s ban or restrictions, 29 are in Africa. PAGE A4

Russian Tanker Remains Adrift
Despite fears of environmental disaster, no country has intervened after a drone strike in the Mediterranean. PAGE A5

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Loud Nights and Quiet Days
A new album by Avalon Emerson, an influential D.J. at one of Berlin’s most storied clubs, catalogs the angst of 30-something creative life. PAGE C1



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Venezuela Wins It and Weeps
The nation edged the U.S. for the World Baseball Classic title, and players’ tears showed how much it meant. PAGE B9

Searching for the Slipper
As the N.C.A.A. tournament’s round of 64 begins, some wonder if the magic of Cinderella runs is vanishing. PAGE B8

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Crypto Grab on Treasury Bonds
The issuers of stablecoins, which are pegged to the dollar, are buying up U.S. Treasuries as the cryptocurrency grows in popularity. But regulators and bankers warn of systemic risks. PAGE B1

Silicon Valley Backs Anthropic
Tech companies, reluctant to directly confront Trump administration officials over their contract feud with the A.I. start-up, are working behind the scenes to push back on the Pentagon. PAGE B1

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Tales of a Father’s Secrets
Tom Junod, a star writer from the heyday of magazines, reveals how his larger-than-life father drove the narratives of his stories. PAGE D6

